Information or Accountability?

The 1869 Repeal of the Dutch Newspaper Stamp and Parliamentary Speech

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Abstract

Legislators follow the press, but it is not known why. Newspapers may be a cheap source of information about a world that legislators cannot otherwise observe, or they may reach the people to whom legislators are electorally accountable. In modern democracies the readers of newspapers and the voters are largely the same people, so the two explanations are observationally equivalent. This paper separates them in a setting where readers and voters were different populations: the Netherlands between 1850 and 1888.

On 1 July 1869 the Dutch state abolished the *dagbladzegel*, the stamp duty levied on every copy of a newspaper, together with the duty on advertisements. The stamp had taken up to 57 per cent of a subscription price, and its repeal opened the way for cheaper titles and a reading public that grew over the following decade. The franchise did not move: the electoral law of 1850 fixed a tax census by statute, and until the revision of 1887 only about one adult man in eight or nine could vote. Whatever cheaper newspapers did to Dutch politics, they did it to a parliament whose electorate had not changed, in front of a reading public that by law largely could not vote.

The Dutch parliament also offers a natural comparison. The Tweede Kamer was elected directly by the census voters, half of it renewed every two years. The Eerste Kamer, chosen by the Provincial States from the most heavily assessed taxpayers for nine-year terms, read the same newspapers and debated the same bills, but its members did not face voters. If legislators respond to the press because its readers can sanction them, the repeal should change speech in the lower chamber more than in the upper one, more among members facing re-election soon, and more towards the titles that voters read. If the press matters as a source of information, the response should not depend on electoral exposure.

The paper builds two new corpora. The first covers the proceedings of both chambers from 1847 to 1889, about 5,400 sittings and 65,000 pages of OCR text from Staten-Generaal Digitaal, segmented into speeches and linked to members through their service records, with the accuracy of attribution measured on a blind-coded sample. The second is an article-level corpus of the digitised Dutch press for 1848–1879 from the open archive of the Koninklijke Bibliotheek, restricted to titles observed on both sides of the reform. Speeches and articles are classified into policy areas with a transformer model adapted to nineteenth-century Dutch and trained on hand-coded data; the main outcome measures how closely each speech follows the topics the press covered in the preceding month.

The empirical strategy compares the two chambers before and after July 1869 in an event-study design, with member and period fixed effects absorbing the media environment and the composition of each chamber. Because only two chambers are compared, inference relies on placebo dates rather than conventional clustering. Comparisons within the lower chamber (members due for re-election against those just elected, the same bill debated in both chambers, established titles against cheap ones) sharpen the mechanism, and the entry of newspapers across electoral districts provides a second source of variation. The design addresses the main

threats directly: the periodic election held three weeks before the reform, the simultaneous repeal of the advertisement duty, and differences in the quality of the printed record.

The answer matters beyond the nineteenth century. If legislators follow the press because of its readers' votes, much of what is attributed to media influence on politics is a statement about electoral accountability, and it should vary with electoral institutions — a prediction that bears directly on current debates about the decline of local news and political responsiveness.

Keywords: media and accountability; newspaper taxation; parliamentary speech; bicameralism; historical political economy; the Netherlands.
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